

success MANTRA

Never make the same mistake twice and never compromise on being the best in the field

biggest OBSTACLE

"I once relied on partners for expansion. But they were only interested in local business."

first BLOOD

Metropolis is credited with introducing HIV drug resistance tests in India for the first time



11 per cent of the revenue inflows. With a team of nearly 2,500 people across centres—including 500 in Mumbai alone—Shah's labs also have the singular distinction of conducting 3,700 varieties of tests at the Mumbai centre and designing nearly 600 new tests every year.

While its present-day position is envi-

able, Metropolis faced considerable challenges during its growing years. When he first started out as a pathologist, along with running his own lab, Shah was also hot-footing between pathology centres at local hospitals and pharmaceutical companies. "My other commitments allowed me only a few hours in my lab. I realised the damage this was doing when people called asking for Dr Shah and never found me available," explains Shah. That is why, in 1994, Shah decided to change the status quo. He gave up his numerous associations and turned his energies to developing his own labs—a dream that he had yearned to fulfil for many years. "I believed that pathology labs should operate like prostitutes. To be successful, you had to be available to everyone all the time," laughs Shah.

Since Shah's lab in Mumbai was already running smoothly, he started expanding his business gradually, by setting up labs in Jaipur, Chennai and Hyderabad, in association with local partners. However, the decision, which Shah says was his greatest professional mistake, cost him dear. "The local partners were only concerned about the growth of business locally. The success of Metropolis as a brand did not matter to them," explains Shah. This resulted in the Hyderabad lab closing down in eight months and the Jaipur venture also faring badly. Thereafter, he roped in his daughter Ameera Patel, a management graduate from Austin University, US, who helped him put in place a management and experts team by 2001. This was also the time when profit margins for pathology laboratories were taking a dip in India. "The costs were on the rise, but the end users continued to pay meagre sums," says Shah. The next best thing was, therefore, to look for options abroad. That saw his business going to Africa, Middle East and parts of South-East Asia.

Today, Metropolis is a dynamic business that continues to spread its wings. He may not be politically correct but he is grounded. All he says about his rise is, "I could have done better."

by Swati Mathur